

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Records: Arts leader quit amid inquiry

Investigation accuses Hedspeth of violating harassment rules

By Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson's arts and culture leader resigned amid an investigation into allegations that she harassed staffers, records obtained by the Tribune show.

The early October exit of Clinée Hedspeth, commissioner of the Department of Cultural Affairs and Special Events, came days after Johnson's chief of staff received a human resources investigation determining Hedspeth violated ethnic, age-based and sexual harassment rules.

Hedspeth denied she acted inappropriately, the Department of Human Resources investigation report shows.

The sudden resignation of Hedspeth, a close friend of Johnson's before her appointment who worked as his legislative director when he was a county commissioner, marks the latest instance of a longtime Johnson associate leaving his administration amid controversy.

Though Hedspeth resigned, Johnson spokesperson Cassio Mendoza said the mayor followed the discipline recommendations given by the Department of Human Resources and planned to fire her. The recommendation was not visible in the heavily redacted report.

"The former commissioner resigned before she could be terminated," Mendoza wrote in a statement Tuesday morning. Hedspeth has been placed on the city's "ineligible for rehire" list, he added.

Hedspeth, who became commissioner in March 2024 after Johnson fired Mayor Lori Lightfoot appointee Erin Harkey, oversaw high turnover in her department. Under her leadership, nearly 30 staffers, including seven top deputies, have been fired or resigned from the department

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Law enforcement officers watch people protest outside the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement holding facility in Broadview on Saturday. ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

'It was too much'

Broadview detainees detail dirty, overcrowded facility in court

By Madeline Buckley
Chicago Tribune

Pablo Moreno Gonzalez, who was detained at the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement holding facility in Broadview for three days in October, was telling a judge about trying to sleep in a dirty and crowded holding cell when he began crying and pressing his fists to his forehead.

"It was too much," he said in Spanish, through a translator, while wiping his eyes with a tissue.

Moreno Gonzalez, 56, is among a group of former Broadview detainees raising the alarm about allegedly harrowing conditions at

the west suburban facility, where they say those in custody are kept from attorneys and tricked into signing deportation forms. During a full-day hearing Tuesday at the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse, five people who were detained there in September or October offered rare accounts of a facility that has been called a "black box" by attorneys who have struggled to make contact with clients there.

Less than a week after attorneys filed a class-action lawsuit alleging inhumane conditions at the processing center, attorneys on behalf of the detainees asked U.S. District Judge Robert Gettleman to allow lawyers confidential

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■ Feds say Border Patrol vehicle tied to Brighton Park shooting wasn't repaired prior to inspection. **Chicagoland, Page 2**
■ ICE pushes Chicago restaurants in immigrant neighborhoods into survival mode. **Food & Health**

access to their clients and issue a restraining order prohibiting the government from holding people in substandard conditions. If those terms cannot be met, they argued, the facility should not house people for more than 12 hours.

Gettleman said he wanted to

"give more thought" to how to fashion a temporary restraining order, but he spoke plainly about the reported conditions of the center, calling it disturbing and "unnecessarily cruel." He said he will issue an order Wednesday.

"It has really become a prison," Gettleman said. "The conditions would be found unconstitutional even in the context of prisons holding convicted felons, but these are not convicted felons. These are civil detainees."

Government attorneys have contested the allegations raised by the plaintiffs, but acknowledged that they have not yet

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Speaker of the House Mike Johnson walks to the podium before speaking at a news conference on Tuesday on Capitol Hill in Washington, D.C. TOM BRENNER/GETTY

Cracks emerge in federal shutdown

Bipartisan talks in Senate as Trump threatens SNAP aid

By Lisa Mascaro and Mary Clare Jalonick
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Signs of a potential end to the government shutdown intensified Tuesday with behind-the-scenes talks, as the federal closure was on track to become the longest ever disrupting the lives of millions of Americans.

Senators from both parties, Republicans and Democrats, are quietly negotiating the

contours of an emerging deal. With a nod from their leadership, the senators seek a way to reopen the government, put the normal federal funding process back on track and devise some sort of resolution to the crisis of expiring health insurance subsidies that are spiking premium costs from coast to coast.

"Enough is enough," said Senate Majority Leader John Thune, the South Dakota Republican, as he opened the deadlocked chamber.

On day 35 of the federal government shutdown, the record for the longest will be broken after midnight. With

SNAP benefits interrupted for millions of Americans depending on federal food aid, hundreds of thousands of federal employees furloughed or working without pay and contracts being delayed, many on and off Capitol Hill say it's time for it to end.

Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy predicted there could be chaos in the skies next week if the shutdown drags on and air traffic controllers miss another paycheck. Labor unions put pressure on lawmakers to reopen the government.

Turn to Shutdown, Page 12

Madigan appeals corruption conviction

Says prosecutors flouted rulings reining in use of bribery, fraud statutes

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

Three weeks after former House Speaker Michael Madigan reported to federal prison, his lawyers have filed a long-awaited appeal to overturn his corruption conviction, arguing the prosecution flouted recent Supreme Court rulings reining in the use of the bribery and fraud statutes and instead stretched the laws "past their breaking points."

The 71-page filing with the 7th U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals said allegations surrounding two of the central prongs in the case — the ComEd bribery scheme and Madigan's offer to help then-Ald. Daniel Solis get a state board position — "improperly criminalizes the rough-and-tumble business of state politics in direct contradiction of recent Supreme Court rulings."

Madigan's lawyers also accused the U.S. attorney's office of "throwing years' worth of legislative action and political relationships at the jury in the hopes of making something stick."

"To be sure, the evidence

Turn to Madigan, Page 4

DICK CHENEY 1941-2025



MARK WILSON/GETTY 2011

One of nation's most powerful, polarizing VPs

Dick Cheney, a hard charging conservative and leading advocate for the 2003 invasion of Iraq, has died at 84. George W. Bush's vice president died Monday from complications of pneumonia and cardiac and vascular disease, his family said Tuesday. **Nation & World inside Business, Page 5**

Toymaker at center of case on tariffs

The Supreme Court will hear arguments on Wednesday in a case brought by Vernon Hills toymaker over Trump tariffs. **Business**

Pitcher's journey from ace to displaced

Cubs starter Shota Imanaga has opted for free agency after he and the Cubs declined to exercise their mutual options. **Chicago Sports**

